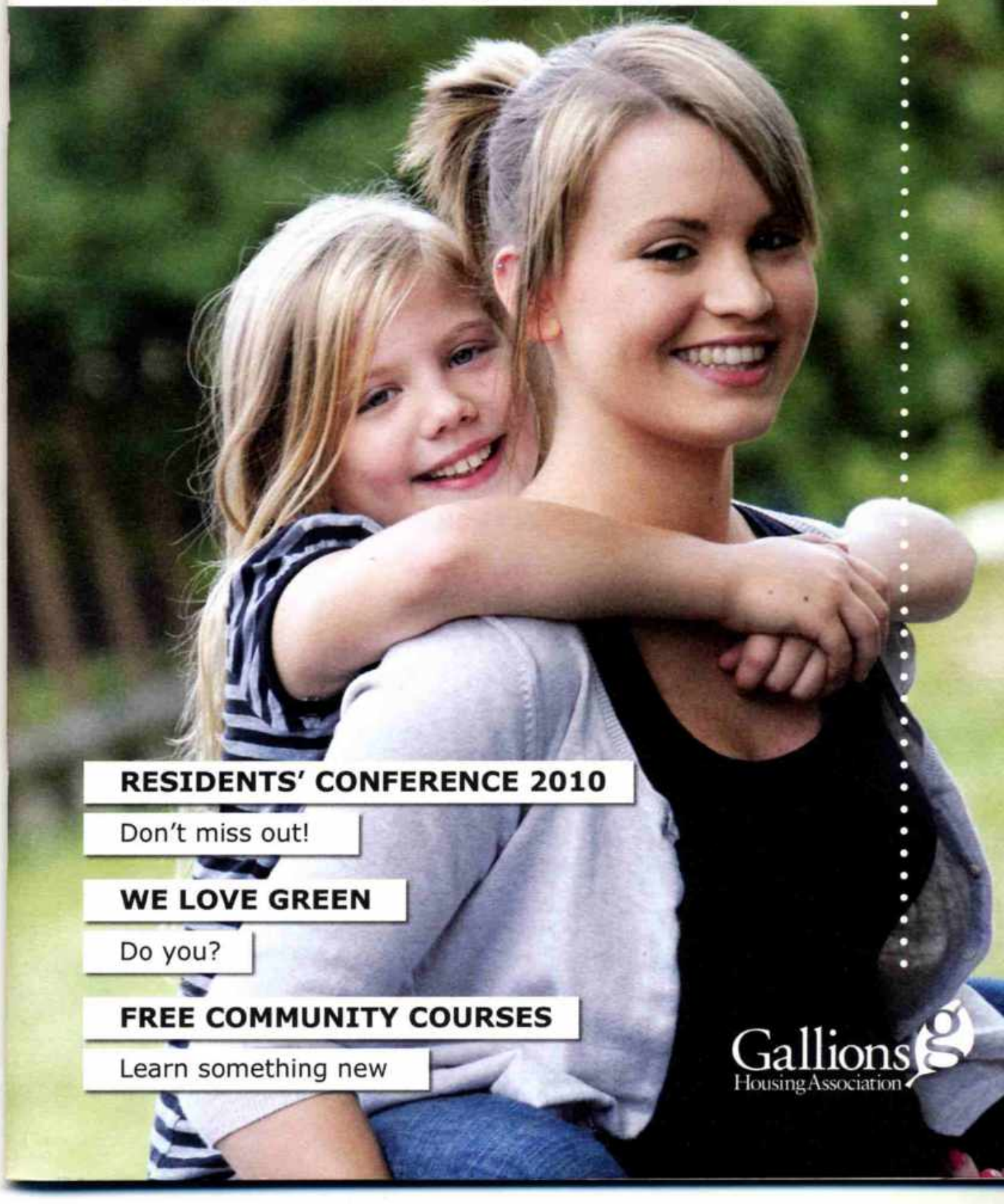
thamesview

Your magazine from Gallions • gallionsha.co.uk • July 2010



RESIDENTS' CONFERENCE 2010

Don't miss out!

WE LOVE GREEN

Do you?

FREE COMMUNITY COURSES

Learn something new

Gallions Housing Association

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WELCOME

In this issue of Thamesview we have featured lots of activities you can get involved with this summer, from starting a food garden to joining a self defence class!

We have some fantastic articles written especially for you by members of the Gallions Residents Group too. I hope you enjoy them and if you have any feedback just email or call us using the details below.

EDITOR
Anita Dagger
0208 308 4086
thamesview@gallionsha.co.uk

RESIDENT EDITOR
Adrian Gogerly

CAREERS AT GALLIONS

We publicise all our current employment opportunities on our website. We are always looking for talented individuals to join our team so if you can't find a vacancy that suits you, just sign up to our talent pool.

COMPLAINTS, COMMENTS AND COMPLIMENTS

Please contact us if you have something to share about our service. We don't mind whether it's good or bad because we use all feedback to improve what we do.
Complaints@gallionsha.co.uk • www.gallionsha.co.uk • 0800 83 84 81

PUBLICATION DETAILS

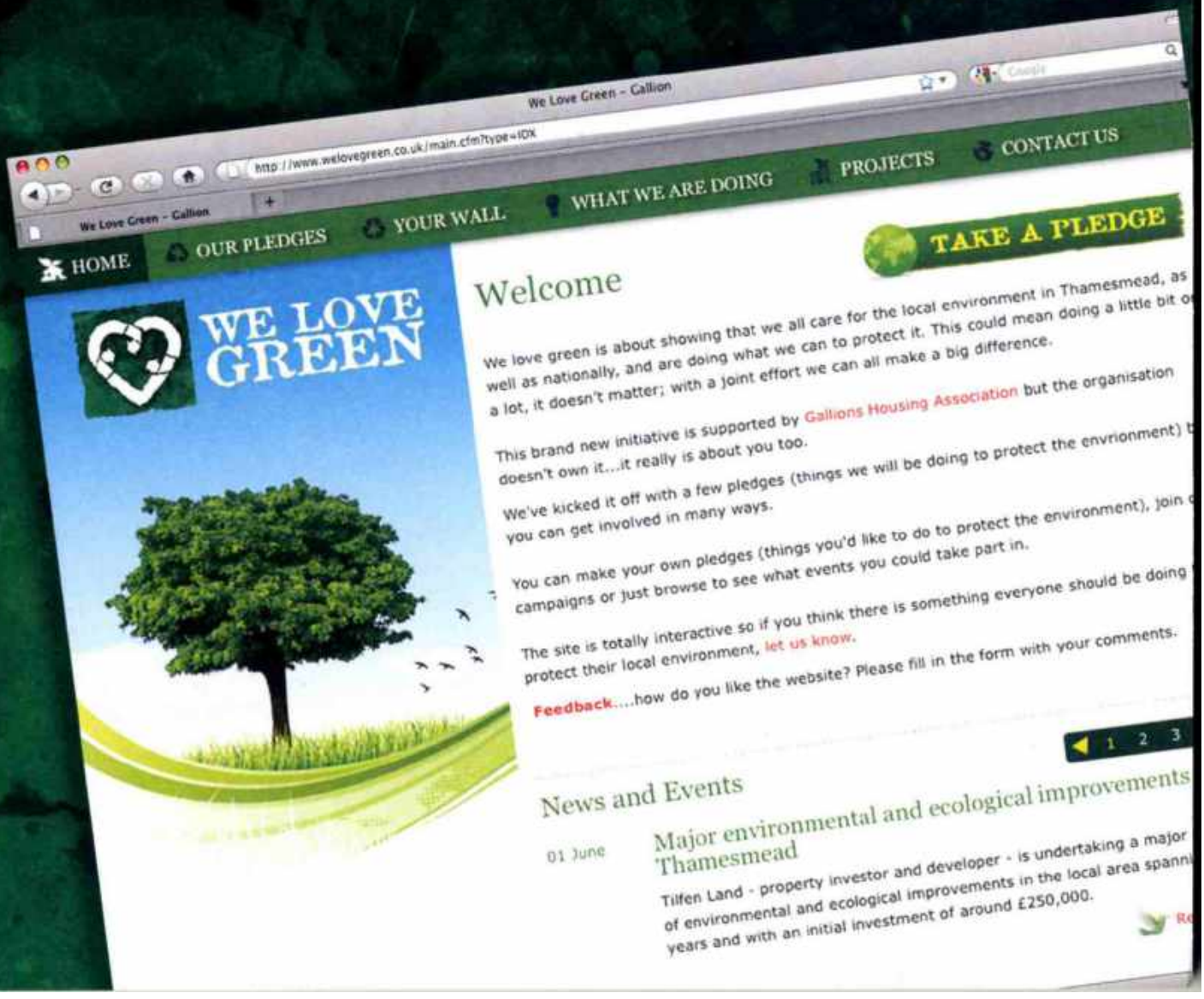
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Gallions Housing Association

WE LOVE GREEN... DO YOU?

At Gallions we think it's really important to protect the local environment so we have started the brand new we love green campaign. Visit our interactive website at www.welovegreen.co.uk for top tips on being green, saving money and improving the area you live in. Make a pledge to reduce your carbon footprint and you could grab one of the 50 re-usable jute shopping bags we are giving away! If you don't have internet access call us on 0800 83 84 81 to find out more.



ANNUAL RESIDENTS' CONFERENCE 2010

At this year's residents' conference we will be celebrating 10 years of Gallions with 10 prizes to giveaway! The jam-packed day promises to be the best ever with circus skills fun, a 'birthday' lunch, local offers workshops, goody bags, free benefit health checks and much more. Plus, it's totally free to attend! Fill in the form below and return it to us by 3rd September 2010 to reserve your place.



10am - 2pm on Saturday 2 October 2010
Business Academy Bexley, Yarnton Way, Erith, DA18 4DW

Return to: Kelly Sullivan, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost SE6691, London, SE2 9BR.

Name: .....

Address: .....

Email address: .....

Telephone: .....

We will call you to confirm your place and tell you more about the day's activities.

FANCY A COMMUNITY FOOD GARDEN?



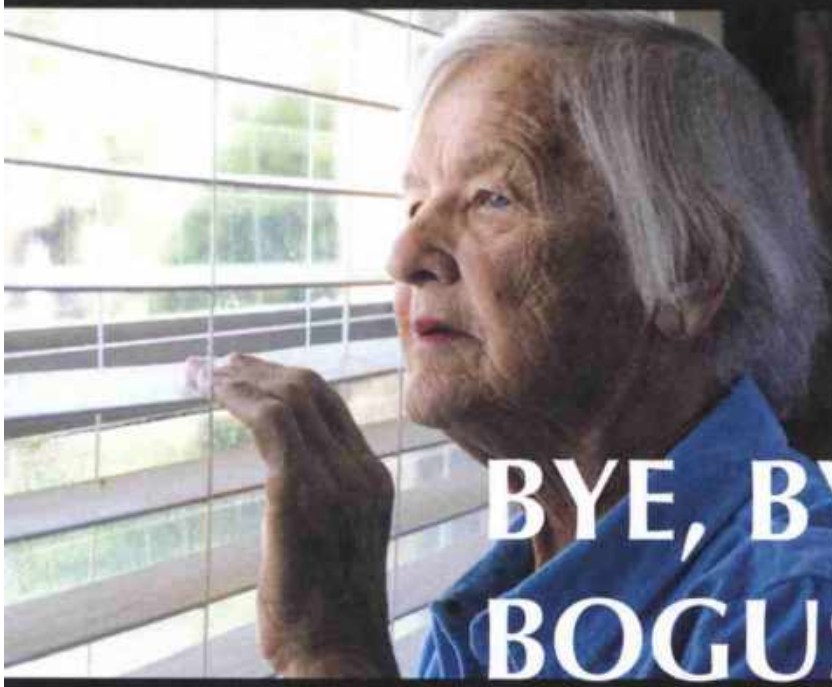
Capital Growth is a great initiative designed to help Londoners get into gardening and create local spaces to grow fruit and vegetables. By joining in you could meet new people, enjoy healthy food and transform your local environment. You don't need to be an expert gardener to take part, you can offer a piece of land to be used as a garden or just volunteer your time. What's more, Capital Growth is currently running a competition to find the best community growing space within a social housing area, with great prizes to be won!

Logon to www.capitalgrowth.org or call 020 7837 1228 to find out more about getting involved and for competition entry details.



FREE LOCAL COURSES!

If you want to learn a new skill or get a qualification then get yourself down to the enrolment day at the Southlake Centre, Seacourt Road, SE2 9XB on Tuesday 7th September between 10am and 2pm. There are lots of courses to choose from, including computing, first aid, photography, hairdressing and many more. Best of all it's free if you have a low income, are claiming benefits or volunteer in the London Borough of Bexley! Call Jas Dhillon on 01322 552561 or email jaswinder.dhillon@adultedbexley.org for more information.



BYE, BYE TO BOGUS CALLERS

A bogus caller is someone who tricks their way into a person's home to steal money and valuables. Bogus calls often peak during the summer months and are sometimes targeted at older people so follow these top tips to help protect yourself:

1. All electricity, gas and water companies have a doorstep password scheme. Contact your provider to set up a password that will be used when you are visited

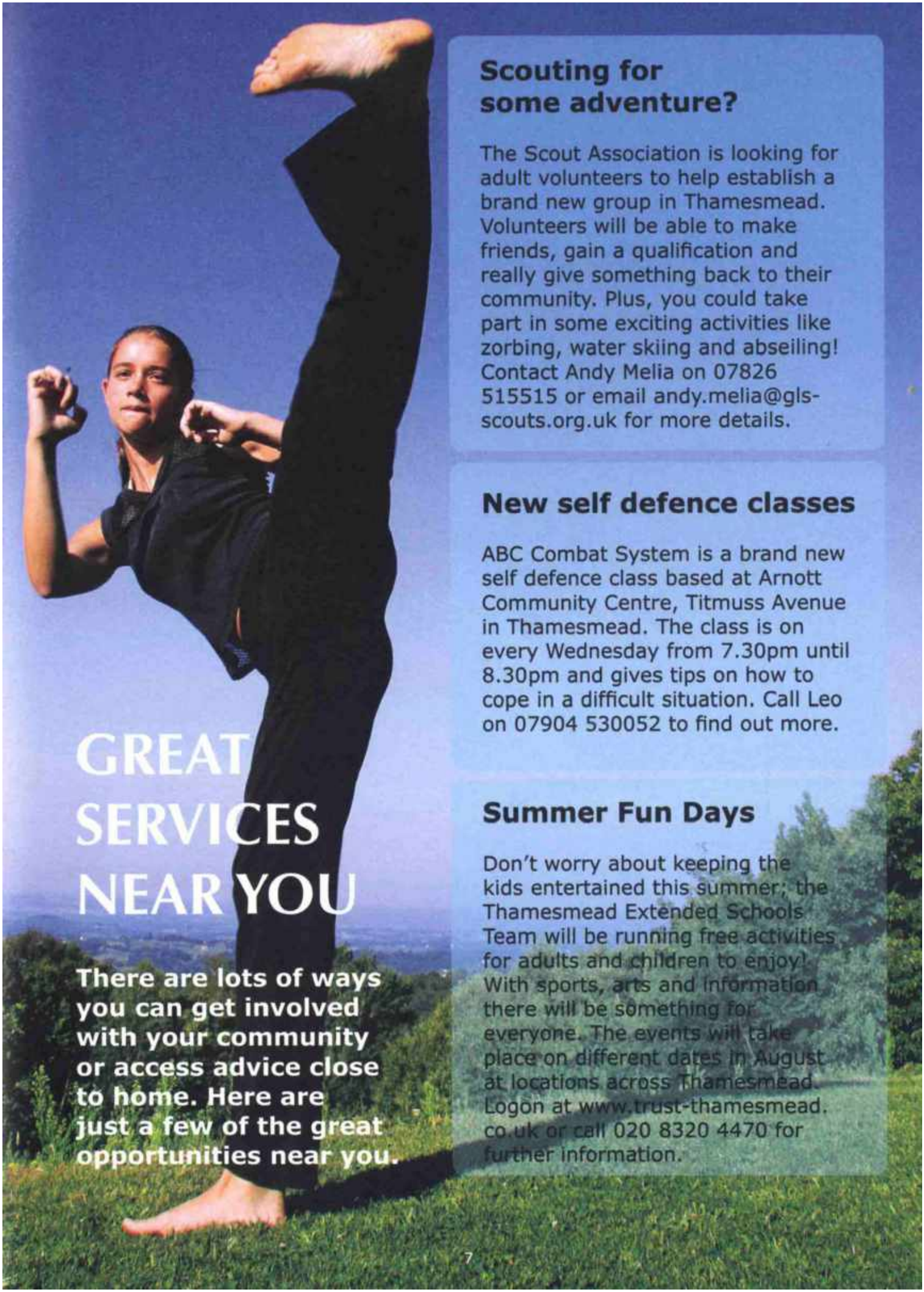
2. If you aren't expecting a visitor, find out who is outside before you open the door. Use a spy hole, chain or look through a window

3. Always check a visitor's identification badge and if you are still unsure call the company before opening your door

4. Do not keep large amounts of money at home and keep all valuables out of sight

5. Call 999 if you are in immediate danger

Visit www.ageuk.org.uk/home-and-care or call 0800 169 65 65 to get more advice and information.



GREAT SERVICES NEAR YOU

There are lots of ways you can get involved with your community or access advice close to home. Here are just a few of the great opportunities near you.

Scouting for some adventure?

The Scout Association is looking for adult volunteers to help establish a brand new group in Thamesmead. Volunteers will be able to make friends, gain a qualification and really give something back to their community. Plus, you could take part in some exciting activities like zorbing, water skiing and abseiling! Contact Andy Melia on 07826 515515 or email andy.melia@gls-scouts.org.uk for more details.

New self defence classes

ABC Combat System is a brand new self defence class based at Arnott Community Centre, Titmuss Avenue in Thamesmead. The class is on every Wednesday from 7.30pm until 8.30pm and gives tips on how to cope in a difficult situation. Call Leo on 07904 530052 to find out more.

Summer Fun Days

Don't worry about keeping the kids entertained this summer; the Thamesmead Extended Schools Team will be running free activities for adults and children to enjoy! With sports, arts and information there will be something for everyone. The events will take place on different dates in August at locations across Thamesmead. Logon at www.trust-thamesmead.co.uk or call 020 8320 4470 for further information.

DATES FOR YOUR DIARY



SIGNS OF THE SEA - 6 AUGUST

Get down to the Old Royal Naval College, Greenwich this summer to find out about life on the seas. You'll have the chance to paint a sea-themed tile to take home too. A great day out for little ones at just £1 per child! Call 020 8269 4747 or visit www.oldroyalnavalcollege.org for more details.

PUNCH AND JUDY - 9-13 AUGUST

Enjoy a traditional family day out at Greenwich Park with Punch, Judy, the baby and the crocodile. An experience not to be missed and best of all it's free! Visit www.royalparks.org.uk or call 020 8858 2608 for more information.

FAMILY BAT WALK - 1 SEPTEMBER

Don't miss a very special family night out at Hall Place and Gardens, Bexley! You will learn all about bats before heading out on a dusk walk with 'bat detectors' to listen to them. Call 01322 621238 to book your tickets at £6 per person, which includes tea and cake.

THE THAMES FESTIVAL - 11 & 12 SEPTEMBER

This free annual event takes place on and around the River Thames from Westminster Bridge to Tower Bridge. There will be street arts, music, food and drink, with a fantastic fireworks finale. Visit www.thamesfestival.org or call 020 7928 8998 to find out more.

MEET THE RUXLEY ANIMALS - 7 OCTOBER

Head over to Ruxley Manor Garden Centre, Sidcup from 3pm to meet a whole host of characters including reptiles, insects and fish! This is a free event and no booking is required. Visit www.bexley.gov.uk or call 020 8303 7777 for full details.

HALLOWEEN WORKSHOP - 30 OCTOBER

Visit Charlton House with your little ones to take part in a great Halloween craft workshop. This event is free and children must be accompanied by an adult. Visit at www.greenwich.gov.uk or call 0208 854 8888 for information.

Editor's note: Thamesview does not endorse or recommend any clubs, groups or events listed. We aim to provide accurate and up to date information but cannot be held responsible for any misleading or inaccurate information supplied to us.

WIN WITH OUR SEASIDE WORDSEARCH

In this wordsearch we have hidden the names of six popular UK seaside resorts. Find them all and you could win a fantastic picnic hamper kit to enjoy this summer holiday season!

BLACKPOOL
BOURNEMOUTH
BRIGHTON
NEWQUAY
SKEGNESS
WHITBY

Z	Q	X	P	C	C	V	R	Q	M	W	V	E
Q	R	E	T	R	Y	T	U	U	I	N	O	Z
P	H	N	F	S	N	O	T	H	G	I	R	B
G	C	E	U	J	S	K	R	L	Z	N	X	H
C	V	W	V	B	F	N	L	M	A	Q	L	W
W	V	Q	T	R	X	T	O	Y	W	U	I	S
B	O	U	R	N	E	M	O	U	T	H	D	S
M	Q	A	W	I	E	T	P	L	T	I	Y	E
U	G	Y	T	O	U	P	K	Z	A	X	C	N
B	A	N	R	M	B	Q	C	W	B	E	I	G
T	Q	Y	A	U	S	I	A	O	G	P	J	E
N	H	B	A	V	B	C	L	X	T	Z	Y	K
A	A	E	H	Q	A	Y	B	T	I	H	W	S

DID YOU KNOW...

16 million tourists visit Blackpool every year and send two million postcards! Blackpool is home to the world's tallest and fastest rollercoaster - The Pepsi Max Big One, which is 235ft high and reaches speeds of 85mph. Each summer hungry visitors at Blackpool Pleasure Beach munch their way through 47 miles of hot dog sausages!

Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Anita Dagger, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost SE6691, London, SE2 9BR or drop it into our reception by 20th August 2010. The winner will be selected at random.

Name:
Address:

Telephone:
Email:

Congratulations to Mr Johnston of Hibernia Point who was the winner of our last wordsearch competition.



NEIGHBOURHOOD BLOCK INSPECTIONS

Every month we run Neighbourhood Block Inspections (previously Neighbourhood Walkabouts) so you can meet your Neighbourhood Warden and talk about any issues you have. If you want to join in call us on 0800 83 84 81 to find out where and what time to meet. Here are our August and September dates; check online at www.gallionsha.co.uk or call 0800 83 84 81 for more information.

Abbey Wood

3rd September
St Joseph's Court and Felixstowe Road Flats

Broadwaters

1st September
Bridge House, Whinchat Road Flats, Wren Path, Wigeon Path and Redwing Path

Crossway

12th August
Ringside Court and Phoenix Point

23rd September
Ringside Court and Phoenix Point

Greenmead

2nd September
Lime Row Flats

Lesnes

2nd September
Coralline Walk and Evenlode House

8th September
Radley House, Duxford House, Hibernia Point, Wyfold House, Maplin House and Clewer House

Moorings

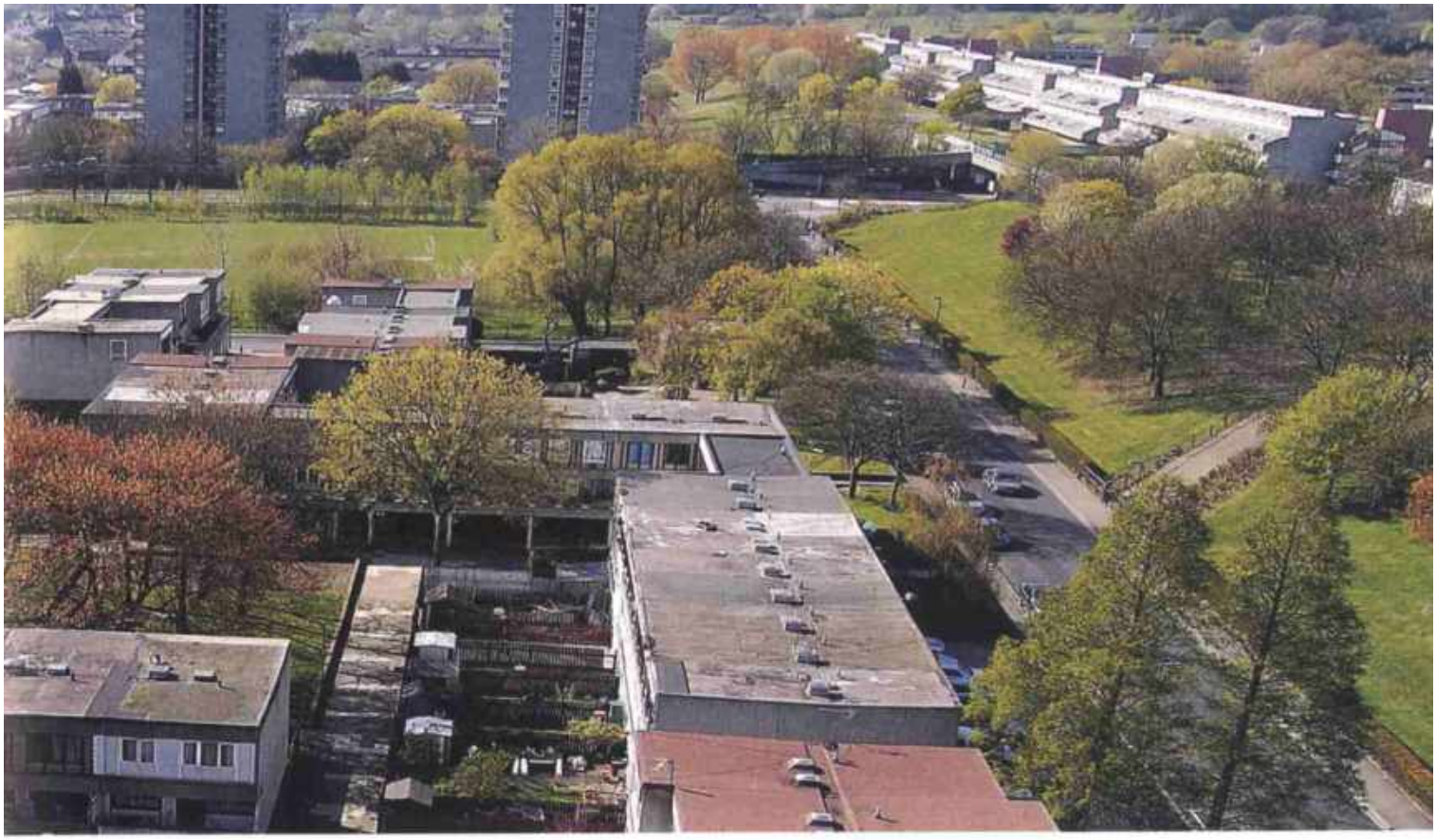
10th August
Keynes Court, Curtis Way, Titmuss Avenue, Webb Court, Raymond Postgate Court, Lansbury Court, Hammond Way and Beveridge Court

19th August
Simon Court, Chadwick Court, Manning Court, Macaulay Way, Besant Court, Booth Close, Mill Court and Cross Court

25th August
Harold Wilson House

21st September
Keynes Court, Curtis Way, Titmuss Avenue, Webb Court, Raymond Postgate Court, Lansbury Court, Hammond Way and Beveridge Court

30th September
Simon Court, Chadwick Court, Manning Court, Macaulay Way, Besant Court, Booth Close, Mill Court and Cross Court



Parkview

3rd August
Lucerne Court, Buckwheat Court, Teeswater Court and Shire Court

17th August
Argali House, Dexter House, Harlequin House and Muscovy House

24th August
Timothy House, Trefoil House, Clydesdale House, Jacob House and Masham House

10th September
Maran Way

14th September
Lucerne Court, Buckwheat Court, Teeswater Court and Shire Court

28th September
Argali House, Dexter House, Harlequin House and Muscovy House

Slade Green

3rd September
Old Church Court

Southmere

5th August
Tavy Bridge and Binsey Walk

9th September
Osney House, Penton House, Trewsbury House, and Oakenholt House

16th September
Tavy Bridge and Binsey Walk

Waterfield

12th August
Disraeli Close and Austen Close Flats

26th August
Cobden Court, Bright Court, Hazlitt Court, Shaftesbury Court, Wilberforce Court and Kingsley Court

23rd September
Disraeli Close and Austen Close Flats

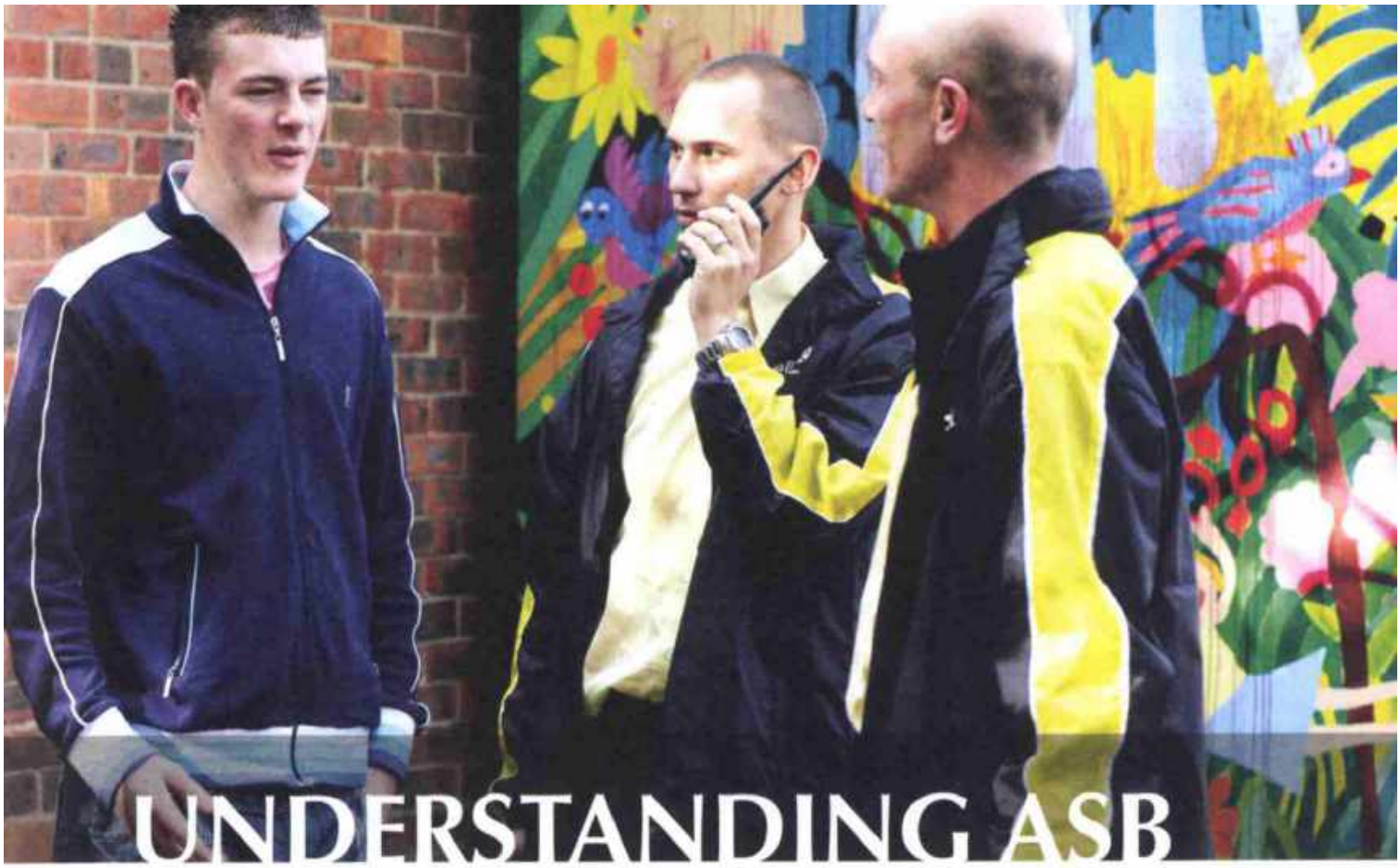
SAY NO TO SUB-LETTING

As a social housing landlord we provide homes to eligible people in housing need. It is unacceptable for residents to abuse their tenancy agreement and profit by unlawfully sub-letting their property to someone else.

Our Enforcement Team investigates all reports of suspected sub-letting and works with the Police and other housing providers to make sure our homes are only occupied by the correct tenants. We can and will evict those found to be sub-letting.

You can call us on 0800 83 84 81, visit our website at www.gallionsha.co.uk or speak to a member of staff if you are concerned about sub-letting where you live. You don't have to give your contact details but if you do we will let you know the outcome of our investigations.





UNDERSTANDING ASB

ASB stands for anti-social behaviour. ASB includes a whole range of activities that damage the quality of life for others. Our new Enforcement Team of two anti-social behaviour officers, five investigating wardens and one team manager is there to investigate all reports of ASB. We categorise the behaviour to make sure we deal with everything in the best way.

- Severe - we will respond straightaway
  This includes violence and vandalism causing danger

- Urgent - we will contact you within 24 hours
  This covers abandoned vehicles posing a risk, serious noise nuisance and offensive graffiti

- Moderate - we will get in touch within 3 days
  This can mean suspicion of illegal activities, intimidation and rubbish dumping

- Minor - we will get back to you within 7 days
  This encompasses dog nuisance, inconsiderate parking and misuse of shared/public areas

To make a report about ASB you can call us on 0800 83 84 81, visit our website at www.gallionsha.co.uk or speak to a member of staff. Your details will remain confidential and we will keep you informed and support you throughout our investigations.

HOMEOWNER NEWS

If you live in flat there will be communal areas in the building that you share with other residents and that Gallions look after. Under the terms of your lease no single occupant can claim any shared area.

Safety and security

Fire safety law states that managing agents and landlords of residential properties must carry out fire risk assessments on all communal areas of a building and make sure that there is a fire policy in place for each block. We recently carried out these risk assessments and found that some residents were leaving personal belongings in communal areas and using electrical intake cupboards and smoke vents for personal storage. This poses a serious fire risk and is not permitted.

It is everyone's duty to make sure that communal areas are kept in reasonable order so if you spot items like bikes, furniture and bulky rubbish in shared corridors, landings or stairwells call us straightaway on 0800 83 84 81. Items found stored in any of the communal areas will be removed.

Paying for major repairs

Gallions has a planned programme of improvements in place to ensure that your property is maintained and improved. In line with your lease, you are asked to contribute to these costs.

We appreciate that for owners of flats in blocks where there is no reserve fund set up, it may be difficult to find the money to pay immediately for the costs of these works. Gallions offers a range of payment options including spreading the cost over a number of years.

Alternatively, you can set up a voluntary charge on your property, which means that you do not have to pay immediately. When you sell your property, Gallions will be paid from the funds you receive from the sale. In these circumstances, Gallions will first apply to the court for a money judgement and then for a charge on your property. Please contact us on 0800 83 84 81 or email leaseholdmanagement@gallionsha.co.uk if you would like more information about paying for major repairs.

HOW WELL ARE WE DOING?

Our latest chart shows our performance as a landlord for a whole year (from 1st April 2009 until 31st March 2010). Contact us on 0800 83 84 81 if you'd like more information about the quality of our services.

Description	2008/9	2009/10	Target	Performance Trend	Current Status
Overall resident satisfaction	77%	77%	75%	↔	☺
Void re-let period (how long it takes to make an empty available to a new tenant – a lower figure is better)	35 days	34 days	28 days	↑	☹
Emergency repairs completed within timescale	97.1%	99.6%	97%	↑	☺
Urgent and routine repairs completed within timescale	96.4%	98.1%	95%	↑	☺
Calls answered within 20 seconds	75.8%	84%	80%	↑	☺
Complaints answered within timescale	100%	92.9%	85%	↓	☺
Complaints resolved at stages 1 or 2	98.2%	97.1%	95%	↓	☺
Percentage of residents satisfied with complaints process	70.5%	79%	70%	↑	☺
Satisfaction with anti-social behaviour process	Not collected (new target)	77.9%	80%	N/A	☹
Rent collected	98.9%	98.7%	100%	↓	☹

Performance Status		Overall Performance Trend	
☹	Performance is below target	↑	Performance is better than last year
☺	Performance is above target	↓	Performance is worse than last year
		↔	Performance is the same as last year

MAXIMISE YOUR INCOME



We recently re-structured our Revenue Management Team to improve the way we help residents stay on track with their rent payments. Our new Income Maximisation Officers are there specifically to help you make the most of your money and get access to the benefits, tax and pension credits, and other support you could be entitled to.

If you are having difficulties keeping up with your rent payments please contact us straightaway on 0800 83 84 81 and we will arrange an appointment for you to see an Income Maximisation Officer. We will also be offering benefit health checks at the next Residents Annual Conference on 2nd October 2010 so make sure you come along if you need information or advice.

SHAPING GALLIONS SERVICES

The Tenant Standards Authority is the regulator for social housing and they have asked all landlords like Gallions to consult with their tenants about possible enhanced service standards for some key services including, Environmental Services (Team Gallions), Repairs, Home Improvements, Anti-Social Behaviour and Resident Engagement.

We really want your views on our ideas so we are holding a number of drop-in sessions for you to look at the proposals and tell us what you think.

The sessions are being held on:

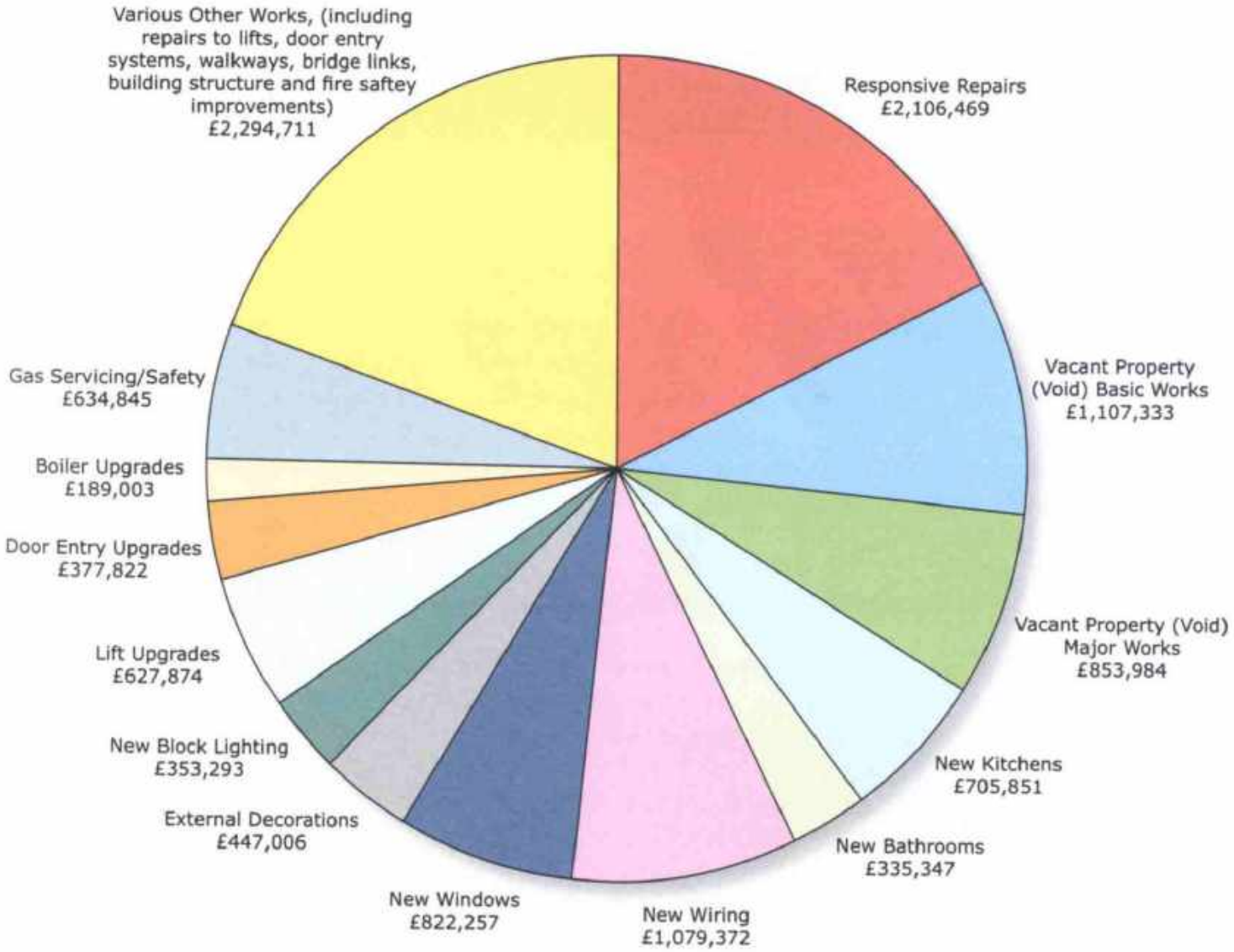
Friday 30th July - Gallions' office reception, Harrow Manor Way - 12pm to 3pm
Wednesday 4th August - Lobby, 31 Millharbour, Isle of Dogs - 4:30pm to 7:30pm
Thursday 12th August - Broadwaters Village Hall, 1c Goosander Way, West Thamesmead - 4:30pm to 7:30pm
Wednesday 18th August - Tavy Bridge Community Hall, Southmere - 4:30pm to 7:30pm

There will also be final focus group meetings towards the end of August.

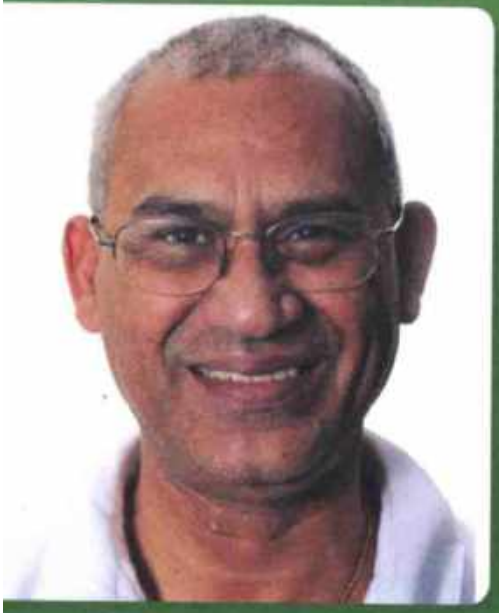
We would like as many people as possible to have a say on the new standards so if you can't make any of the dates and times listed above, please contact the Resident Engagement Team on 0800 83 84 81 and we'll arrange an alternative time for you.

REPAIRS AND MAINTENANCE COSTS

Each year much of our budget is spent on repairing and improving the homes we own. Here is a breakdown of what we spent on our properties from 1st April 2009 until 31st March 2010. If you would like more information about our home improvement programme or need to report a repair call us on 0800 83 84 81 or visit www.gallionsha.co.uk.



Tenants' View



The following pages include stories written by local residents from Gallions Residents Group. We hope to include more news from residents in future so please contact me at adriangogerly@btinternet.com or call 0800 83 84 81 to suggest a topic for this page.

Adrian
Resident Editor

About us

The Gallions Residents Group (GRG) is made up of residents who work together to monitor services and give a resident's perspective on how things run at Gallions. The group is made up of the following members:

Broadwaters area: Adrian Gogerly, Maurice Bradley and Claudette Lawrence
Crossways area: Ray Woodage and Marlene Hunter
Greenmead area: Tony Whiting
Parkway area: Joanne Bernard
Waterfield area: Deborah Frimpong (Chair) and David Rugg

You are welcome to attend the Gallions Residents Group meetings as an observer. The next meetings will take place on 12 August (Annual Review Meeting), 14 October and 16 December.

Gallions is always looking for the best ways to involve and empower residents. If you haven't already been consulted on the type of focus groups or resident panels that you'd like Gallions to run for you, you will be soon. Changes to the role and membership of the Gallions Residents Group are also being considered and we will keep you informed. Get in touch with Helen Chambers, Gallions Residents Group Officer on 0800 83 84 81 or email hchambers@gallionsha.co.uk to find out more.

Marlene

We've been monitoring!

A big part of what the GRG does is monitoring the services that Gallions provides. In the last three months we have looked at:

- Anti-social behaviour
- Cleansing and waste services from Team Gallions
- Rent collection and arrears

When we monitor services we check that Gallions are meeting the targets set for them, make sure services are being delivered properly and find out what improvements are planned. Overall things are on track and we recently agreed with the Revenue Manager that a member of the GRG would attend meetings to give a resident perspective on arrears and possible evictions.

Adrian

Neighbourhood Watch Works

I think it's important to be vigilant about crime and to look out for others in your area so I am a Neighbourhood Watch Co-ordinator. Neighbourhood Watch is a really successful initiative that helps to reduce crime as well as create communities where people care about each other and where they live. As part of the scheme I work with the Police and Trust Thamesmead to tackle local problems in the Glyndon area of the London Borough of Greenwich.

If you would like to join this group contact me on 07783 398 453 or email claudettelawrence123@btinternet.com.

There are Neighbourhood Watch groups across the country and support is available if you want to set up a new one. Visit www.neighbourhoodwatch.net or call 0116 2710052 to find out about a Neighbourhood Watch scheme near you.

Claudette

Tenants' View

Furniture Bank



The Furniture Bank is a scheme that Gallions Residents Group members helped to set up. The idea is to recycle good quality furniture in our community. If you have an unwanted wardrobe, sofa, chest of drawers or something similar that is still in good condition you can donate it. Call 0800 83 84 81 and Gallions will pick up the furniture for free and take it to the Furniture Bank. When the Furniture Bank opens on the last Tuesday of every month from 10am until 12pm another Gallions resident can go to the Old Betting Shop at Tavy Bridge to get your item for free. It's that simple!

Ray

Summertime Block Inspections

Don't forget that Gallions carries out regular block inspections where you live so you can meet with your Neighbourhood Warden and discuss any issues you have.

Upcoming dates are listed on page 10 so try and take part. It really is a good way to get your view across and let Gallions know about problems in your area.

Adrian



Police Safer Neighbourhoods Teams



Every area in London has a Police Safer Neighbourhoods Team, which is usually made up of Police Officers and Police Community Support Officers. These teams work with the community to work out what the local problems are and how to tackle them.

The Police really want people to get involved and it's good to know what is going on where you live, so why not go along to a street briefing, drop-in meeting or community event run by the Police. Put in your post code at www.met.police.uk/saferneighbourhoods to find out about upcoming events, local priorities, news and crime statistics. You can call the Metropolitan Police on 0300 123 1212 to get information too.

Ray



Cash for community groups

Gallions Residents Group has a small amount of funding available to help local community or voluntary groups get equipment, set up new activities or improve their service. Contact Helen Chambers on 0800 83 84 81 if you would like to apply.

Dave

Become a Resident Inspector

Our Resident Inspectors check empty properties before new tenants move in to make sure they are of a good standard. They have done such a great job we are expanding the scheme and looking for new people to take part. Contact us on the usual number to join in.

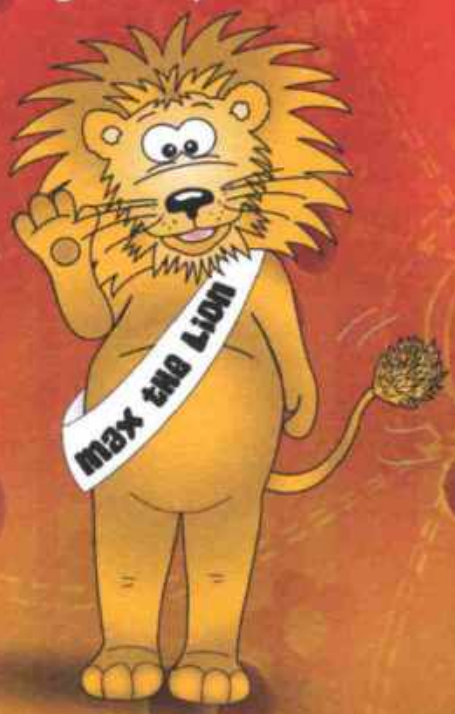
Adrian



Kidsview

ICE CREAM WORDSEARCH

In this wordsearch we have hidden six yummy flavours of ice cream. Find them all and you could win a fantastic summer games pack!



Z	N	A	T	I	L	O	P	A	E	N	A	N
M	I	A	G	S	E	D	I	F	N	G	S	H
J	A	K	N	L	Y	E	E	F	F	O	T	I
U	C	Y	T	T	G	R	R	E	T	E	R	W
B	A	V	C	H	O	C	C	H	I	P	A	Q
N	V	M	M	L	N	J	S	H	W	G	W	F
E	M	N	U	S	A	A	E	L	A	A	B	H
B	S	E	F	V	L	O	S	R	G	L	E	L
A	R	L	L	L	I	M	G	S	I	M	R	U
A	H	S	I	D	N	F	Y	G	A	H	R	I
L	M	N	J	C	E	V	X	F	D	Q	Y	R
F	A	R	E	T	L	A	T	F	D	K	H	N
V	A	O	I	U	N	F	C	H	T	N	I	M

~~Vanilla~~
~~Choc Chip~~
~~Strawberry~~
~~Neapolitan~~
~~Toffee~~
~~Mint~~

This competition is just for kids under 12. Please return your completed wordsearch and details to: Anita Dagger, Gallions Housing Association, Freepost SE66 91 London, SE2 9BR or drop it into our reception by 20th August 2010. The winner will be selected at random.

Child's name:

Parent's name:

Address:

Telephone:

Well done to Tiffany Padmore of Wigeon Path who was the winner of our last competition.